

Yemen After the Red Sea Breakthrough

The Makkah Pact, Iran's Dual-Chokepoint Position and Türkiye's Escalation Risk

CENTRAL JUDGMENT

Saudi Arabia has suffered a material strategic setback in Yemen, but that does not automatically translate into a Turkish combat intervention. The Makkah Joint Defence Agreement materially raises the probability of Turkish and Pakistani support after attacks on Saudi Arabia. Türkiye's most likely contribution is intelligence, ISR, air-defence and maritime support. The principal escalation danger is that Turkish assets enter the theatre before a post-midterm U.S. intensification against Iran, creating an exposure-driven pathway to Türkiye-Iran confrontation.

NERAI Strategic Insights Lab | Research Brief | 13 September 2026 | Corrected edition v2

Lead Analyst: Serhan Ayik | Brussels, Belgium | NERAI-UNRESTRICTED

WHAT CHANGED IN THIS EDITION

This edition was fact-checked line by line against primary and named-outlet reporting. Four substantive revisions were made: (i) the Strait of Hormuz is treated as a **closed and contested** waterway rather than a signalling lever, consistent with its closure since early March 2026; (ii) the 11-12 September shutdown of Saudi Arabia's East-West (Petroline) crude pipeline is incorporated, together with the fact that the drones were launched from Iraq and not by the Houthis; (iii) the Houthi coastal advance is placed in its proximate cause — the collapse of the Yemeni government's 8 September counter-offensive toward Sanaa; and (iv) the Makkah Pact's institutional status is updated to reflect the 31 August committee meeting, the Riyadh secretariat and the Pakistani first secretary-general.

Executive Summary

Bottom line. The Houthi seizure of Mocha and advance to Dhubab and Perim/Mayyun has changed the strategic geometry of the Red Sea. It gives the Houthis a materially stronger position from which to threaten Bab el-Mandeb, although this is not the same as uncontested control of the strait. At the same time, NERAI's corridor layer shows the Strait of Hormuz at -92.2% versus its trailing baseline and Bab el-Mandeb at -21.0% . The resulting system is not symmetrical: Hormuz is a closed waterway that Iran is defending, while Bab el-Mandeb is an open waterway that an Iran-aligned actor can now coerce.

The energy geometry closed in the same week. On 11-12 September drones launched from Iraq's Maysan province struck Saudi Arabia's East-West pipeline, and Riyadh shut the 1,200 km Abqaiq-Yanbu line that had been moving 4-5 million barrels per day. With Hormuz closed since March, that pipeline was the principal bypass. Its loss is the single most consequential development of the period for Saudi exposure — and it did not come from Yemen.

The decisive change is institutional, not only military. On 7 August 2026 Saudi Arabia, Türkiye and Pakistan signed the Makkah Joint Defence Agreement, under which an armed attack against one member is to be regarded as an attack against all. On 31 August the first Strategic Political and Defence Committee met, the pact entered into effect, a permanent secretariat was fixed in Riyadh and the first secretary-general was designated to be Pakistani. Institutionalisation has therefore begun; force generation has not. Pakistan has said no military response has yet been discussed after recent Houthi attacks.

NERAI's net assessment: Türkiye is more likely to enter the crisis first as a security enabler than as a combatant. Intelligence-sharing, ISR, air-defence reinforcement, logistics and maritime escort are substantially more plausible than a Turkish ground campaign in Yemen. If such assets are deployed before or during a renewed U.S. escalation against Iran after the 3 November midterms, the probability of indirect Türkiye-Iran confrontation rises sharply, particularly through Iraq, Syria and Houthi targeting of coalition maritime assets.

Key Judgments

- Saudi Arabia's setback is strategic because Houthi gains threaten the Red Sea outlet Riyadh relies on to reduce exposure to Hormuz — and because that outlet has now been closed from the other end, by drone strikes on the Petroline from Iraqi territory.
- Attacks on Saudi territory are no longer abstract. The Saudi-led coalition reported 73 people wounded on 8 September in Houthi attacks on civilian and energy sites, with fires and halted operations. That makes the Makkah Pact politically relevant even without formal activation.
- Iran's position must be described precisely: Hormuz is closed and militarily contested; Bab el-Mandeb is disruption leverage exercised through an aligned actor. These are two different mechanisms, not one.
- The Makkah Pact materially raises the probability of Turkish support. It does not create an automatic obligation to invade Yemen, but it provides a formal route from Saudi attack → consultation → collective support.
- Türkiye's highest-probability role is non-ground combat support: ISR, intelligence, air defence, logistics and maritime security. These align with Ankara's strengths and minimise domestic political cost.
- A direct Türkiye-Iran war remains a low-probability outcome. The more credible risk is entanglement: Turkish assets deployed under the pact become exposed during a subsequent U.S.-Iran escalation, while Tehran responds indirectly through aligned actors in Yemen, Iraq or Syria.
- The U.S. is already at war with Iran; the relevant post-midterm question is escalation, not entry. Reporting indicates the administration is trying to limit additional exposure before the vote while

leaving open stronger action afterward.

1. The Operational Breakthrough in Yemen

The latest Houthi offensive is strategically important because it changes the relationship between territorial control and maritime coercion. Houthi forces captured Mocha on 10–11 September, entered Dhubab and reached Perim/Mayyun Island at the mouth of Bab el-Mandeb on 12 September. These gains tighten Houthi access to the coast and place forces closer to the shipping lanes linking the Gulf of Aden to the Red Sea.

The proximate cause matters. The advance was not an unprovoked offensive into static lines. On 8 September Yemeni government forces launched a counter-offensive and publicly committed to retaking Sanaa. That operation stalled and then unravelled; the coastal collapse followed. Government commanders described the position as regrouping rather than advancing, and analysts attributed the reversal in part to infighting between the several armies nominally on the same side. Saudi Arabia supported the effort with a substantial air campaign — Houthi military spokesman Yahya Saree claimed 129 air raids in 48 hours by F-15 and Typhoon aircraft — which Riyadh has not publicly acknowledged.

What this does not mean. Occupation of coastal nodes and islands is not equivalent to legal, technical or uncontested control of Bab el-Mandeb. Several major outlets have used the word “control” in headlines; NERAI does not, because the strait remains an international waterway and opposing naval forces retain substantial capability. The operational effect is instead an increase in Houthi surveillance, targeting options, launch geometry and coercive credibility.

Location	Recent development	Strategic value	Assessment
Mocha	Captured 10–11 September as the government offensive collapsed	Port access; coastal logistics; proximity to the southern Red Sea	Confirmed in multiple named-outlet reporting
Dhubab	Houthi entry after government withdrawal	Direct approach to Bab el-Mandeb	Confirmed
Perim / Mayyun	Houthi forces reached the island 12 September; government forces withdrew	Observation and threat position inside the strait	High strategic significance; not equivalent to uncontested strait control
Hodeidah	Long-standing Houthi logistics anchor	Port throughput and northern Red Sea sustainment	NERAI Port Horizon shows continuing operational relevance

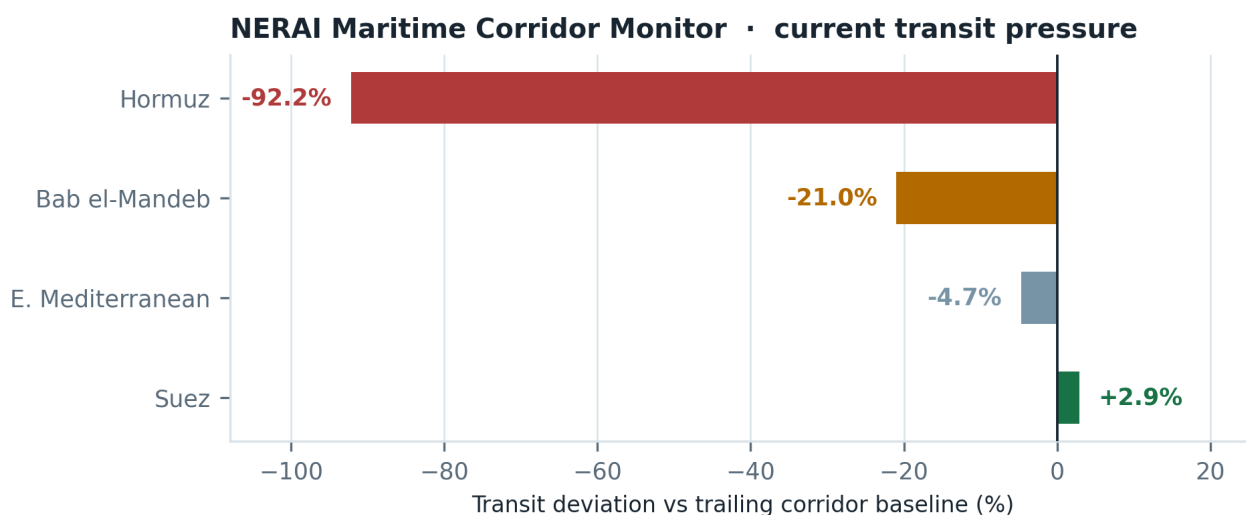


Figure 1. NERAI Maritime Corridor Monitor. Source: NERAI maritime_corridors.json, as of 7 September 2026. Baselines are corridor-specific trailing norms.

2. Why the Saudi-Backed Camp Failed

The failure is best understood as a political-military system problem rather than a simple shortage of Saudi strike capability. The anti-Houthi camp contains actors with incompatible end-states: the internationally recognised government, southern separatists, local militias and externally sponsored formations do not share a single command structure or a single vision for Yemen. This fragmentation reduces the value of superior air power because tactical gains cannot be converted reliably into durable territorial governance — which is precisely what the September counter-offensive demonstrated.

- Fragmented political objectives: anti-Houthi actors are united against the Houthis but divided over the future state.
- Split command: several nominally allied armies competing for influence, with reporting attributing the September reversal partly to infighting among government forces.
- Escalation asymmetry: Saudi economic assets are highly valuable and vulnerable; Houthi forces can impose disproportionate cost through missiles, drones and maritime disruption.
- Missing end-state: Riyadh can punish Houthi forces but has struggled to define a political order that local partners can hold.
- Learning and cohesion advantage: Houthi forces have operated for years under a more centralised command and have repeatedly adapted to airpower and sanctions pressure.
- Saudi risk tolerance has fallen as Vision 2030 and Red Sea infrastructure increase the domestic cost of renewed open-ended war.

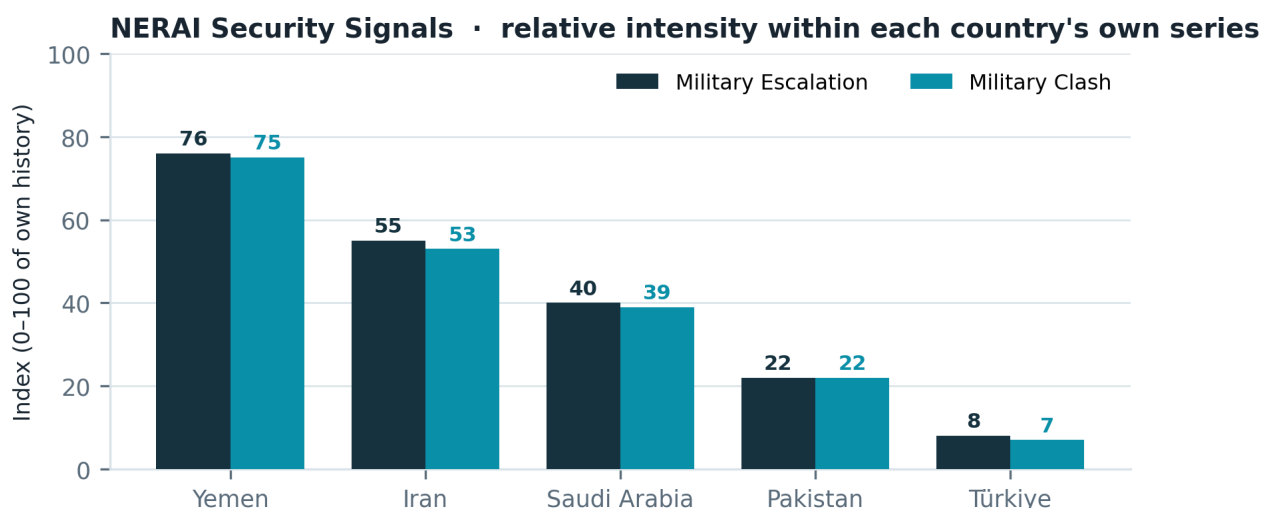


Figure 2. NERA country security signals. Values measure relative intensity within each country's own historical series; they are not cross-country military power scores.

3. Iran's Dual-Chokepoint Position: One Closed, One Coerced

The most common analytical error in this file is to describe Hormuz and Bab el-Mandeb as a single mechanism. They are not. Iran closed the Strait of Hormuz in early March 2026 following the U.S.-Israeli strikes of 28 February; the IRGC restricted passage and claimed control within days, mined the approaches, and has since fought a sustained naval campaign against a U.S.-led coalition. Hormuz is therefore not a signalling lever that Tehran may or may not pull — it is a closed and contested waterway, and the -92.2% transit reading is the measurement of that closure.

Bab el-Mandeb is the opposite case. It remains open, and the Houthi position generates coercion rather than closure. Tehran benefits there if commercial actors believe disruption can recur faster than governments can restore confidence. The result is a coercive mechanism transmitted through insurance, routing, tanker availability, energy prices and political pressure. The two levers are complementary precisely because they operate differently: one removes a route, the other prices one.

Corridor	NERAI transit	Threat score	Mechanism	Strategic reading
Hormuz	-92.2%	49.7	Direct Iranian closure, mining and naval contest	Closed waterway; reopening is a military and political problem, not a commercial one
Bab el-Mandeb	-21.0%	47.9	Houthi coastal and anti-ship capability	Lower absolute disruption, but more geographically durable
Suez	+2.9%	48.2	Upstream exposure to Bab el-Mandeb	Near-baseline transit; see the note below on the positive deviation
Eastern Med.	-4.7%	52.9	Regional spillover risk	High latent threat; limited realised transit loss

ON THE SUEZ READING

Suez running marginally above baseline while Bab el-Mandeb runs 21% below it is counter-intuitive and the cause is not established in the corridor data. The most plausible candidate explanation — offered here as analyst inference, not as a NERAI output — is compositional: Gulf-origin crude that would normally transit Hormuz has largely left the system since March, while Asia-Europe container and non-Gulf liquid traffic has partially normalised through the Red Sea, so the two corridors are no longer measuring the same mix of cargo. This should be treated as a hypothesis to test, not a finding.

NERAI INTERPRETATION

The strategic advantage is asymmetric. Hormuz is where Iran has already spent the lever: the route is shut, the cost is being paid, and the remaining variable is how long Tehran can sustain a closure against a 22-nation coalition. Bab el-Mandeb is where Iran still has an unspent lever, exercised at arm's length through an aligned Yemeni actor with a durable coastal position. Riyadh's exposure sits at the intersection: its Hormuz bypass has now been closed by drones from Iraq, and its Red Sea outlet is the corridor the Houthis can most credibly threaten.

3A. The Petroline Shutdown: Saudi Arabia Loses Its Bypass

On 11-12 September drones launched from Maysan province in south-eastern Iraq struck Saudi Arabia's East-West pipeline and Riyadh shut the line. No group claimed responsibility; analysts attribute the attack to Iran-aligned armed groups in Iraq. This attribution matters analytically: the strike did not come from Yemen, and reading it as a Houthi action would mis-locate both the threat vector and the appropriate response.

The 1,200 km Abqaiq-Yanbu line had been carrying 4-5 million barrels per day, roughly 4-5% of global supply, and was the principal means by which Saudi crude reached the Red Sea without passing through Hormuz. With Hormuz closed since March, its shutdown removes the last significant buffer in the system. Brent was trading above \$104 at the time of writing. The strategic consequence is that Saudi Arabia is now exposed on both of its export geometries simultaneously — the eastern route by Iranian closure, the western route by Iraqi-launched drones and by a Houthi coastal position at the strait the Yanbu route must ultimately traverse.

WHY THIS RAISES PACT PRESSURE RATHER THAN LOWERING IT

A Saudi leadership that has lost both export geometries in the same fortnight has a materially stronger incentive to convert the Makkah Pact from a declaratory instrument into a working one — and a materially weaker incentive to absorb further attrition quietly. This is the mechanism by which an energy-infrastructure event, rather than a battlefield event, becomes the most likely trigger for a formal Saudi request to Ankara and Islamabad.

4. The Makkah Pact Changes the Türkiye-Pakistan Question

The Makkah Joint Defence Agreement is not a speculative social-media construct. It was signed by Saudi Arabia, Türkiye and Pakistan on 7 August 2026, and its official text states that an armed attack against any one of the three states shall be regarded as an attack against them all. On 31 August the parties convened the first Strategic Political and Defence Committee, the agreement took effect, a permanent secretariat was fixed in Riyadh and the first secretary-general was designated to be Pakistani. Turkish Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan described the meeting as the start of building the alliance's institutional structure.

What the pact changes. It raises the political and institutional cost of doing nothing after repeated attacks on Saudi territory, and it gives Riyadh a formal mechanism to request support from Ankara and Islamabad. What it does not do is specify that every attack automatically triggers identical military action by all members. Pakistan's 10 September statement that no military response had yet been discussed confirms that implementation remains discretionary and consultative. The correct reading is that institutionalisation is under way while force generation has not begun.

- The pact makes non-kinetic collective support more likely than before August 2026.
- A Saudi request for ISR, air defence, intelligence or naval support can now be framed as treaty implementation rather than ad hoc intervention.
- Pakistan is likely to emphasise mediation and defensive support before expeditionary combat, consistent with its domestic constraints and 2015 Yemen precedent.
- Türkiye has greater expeditionary capacity and stronger incentives to demonstrate regional security relevance, making Ankara the more plausible provider of visible military support.
- A secretariat in Riyadh with a Pakistani secretary-general gives Saudi Arabia the venue and Pakistan the procedural gatekeeping — an arrangement that favours consultation over rapid activation.

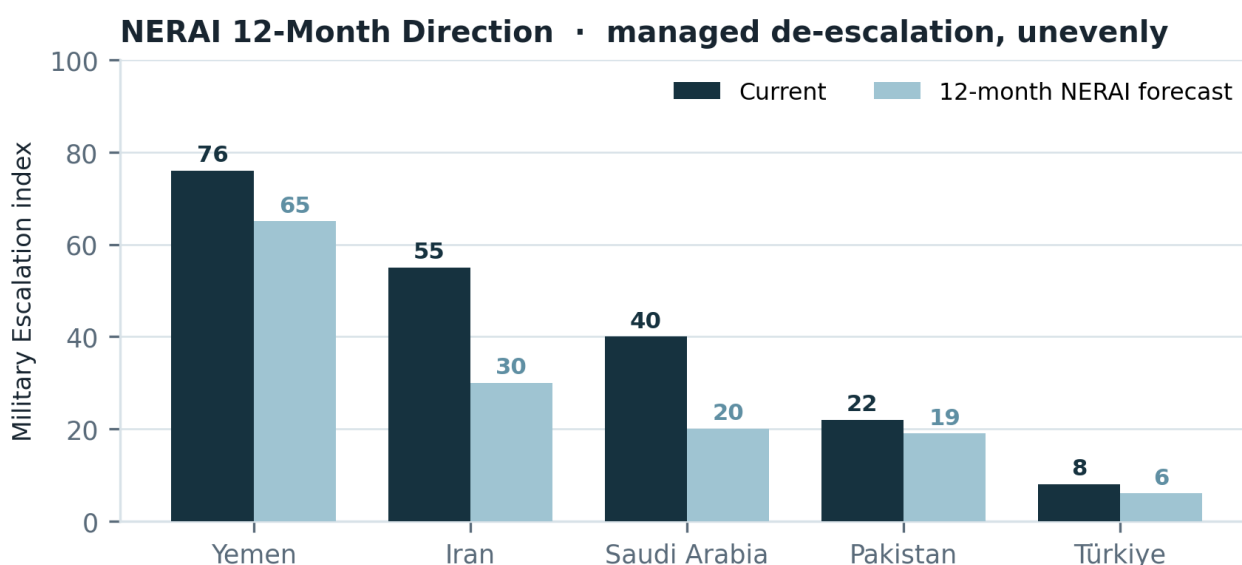


Figure 3. NERAI 12-month Military Escalation direction. These are platform forecasts of index levels, not intervention probabilities.

5. Will Türkiye Intervene to Offset Saudi Arabia's Strategic Loss?

NERAI answer: probably at the support layer; not probably as a ground combatant. The Makkah Pact raises the probability that Türkiye becomes operationally involved if Houthi attacks on Saudi Arabia continue. But Ankara's incentive structure favours contributions that visibly support Saudi defence while keeping Turkish casualties and political ownership limited.

Most likely: intelligence / ISR / targeting support

Türkiye can contribute satellite, UAV, maritime-surveillance and intelligence support without owning the Yemen battlefield. This is the lowest-cost way to demonstrate pact credibility.

Plausible: air-defence reinforcement

Defending Saudi Red Sea infrastructure, airports or critical nodes is easier to justify as collective defence than offensive operations inside Yemen — and the Petroline strike has just made that case for Riyadh.

Plausible: naval escort and maritime security

A Turkish naval contribution to a multinational Red Sea framework would align with collective-defence language while avoiding a ground occupation mission.

Less likely: covert technical support

Advisers, EW, maintenance and limited targeting assistance are possible if Riyadh asks for capabilities rather than formations.

Low probability: Turkish ground combat in Yemen

Terrain, force-protection risk, political ownership and the absence of a clear Yemeni end-state make a Turkish ground campaign strategically unattractive.

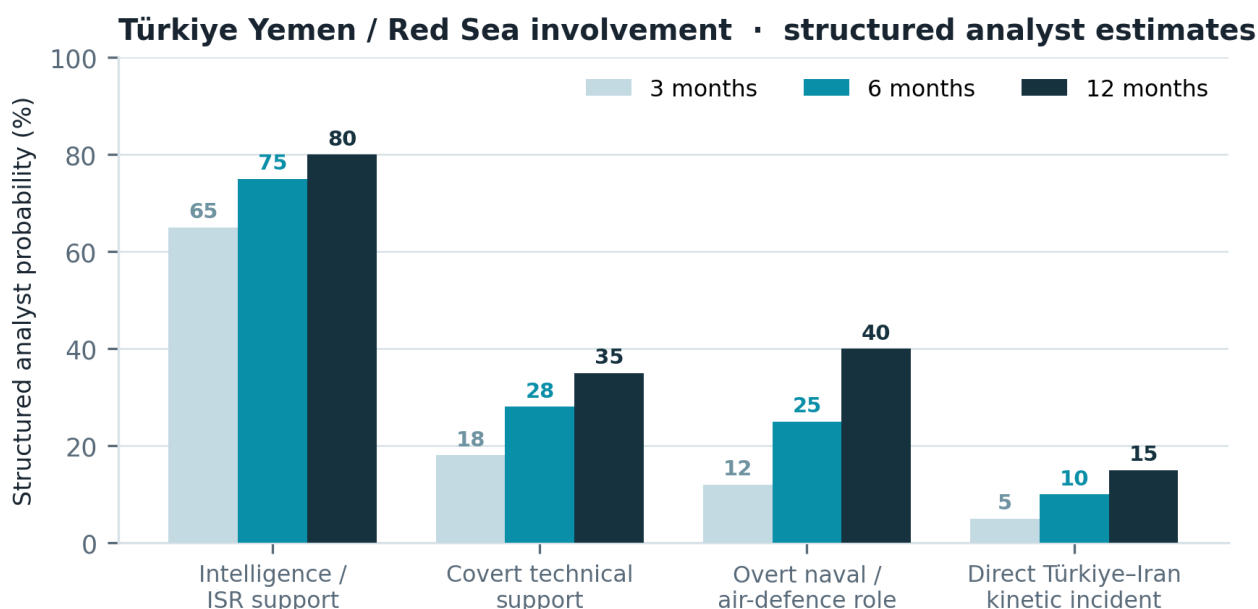


Figure 4. Structured analyst estimates informed by the Makkah Pact, NERAI current/forecast signals and current regional reporting. These probabilities are analyst judgments, not NERAI model outputs.

Scenario estimate notes

- Intelligence / ISR support: 65% at 3 months, 75% at 6 months, 80% at 12 months if attacks on Saudi territory persist.
- Covert technical support: 18% / 28% / 35%, more likely if defensive support fails to reduce Houthi pressure.

- Overt naval / air-defence role: 12% / 25% / 40%; the probability rises most sharply if Riyadh formally invokes the pact, if Red Sea shipping losses increase, or if further strikes close Saudi export infrastructure.
- Direct Türkiye–Iran kinetic incident: 5% / 10% / 15% unconditional. This rises materially if Turkish forces deploy while U.S.–Iran kinetic operations intensify.

6. Pakistan: Treaty Credibility Without a Yemen War

Pakistan matters because the pact makes its restraint strategically visible. Islamabad has already said it remains committed to the agreement while confirming that no military response has yet been discussed. That is not evidence that the pact is irrelevant; it is evidence that the pact is being interpreted through a graduated response model. The designation of a Pakistani first secretary-general reinforces this: Islamabad gains institutional standing without operational obligation.

- Most likely near-term role: diplomacy, intelligence sharing, military planning and defensive support.
- Pakistan can add treaty credibility and manpower depth without leading an expeditionary campaign.
- Its strongest incentive is to prevent a Saudi–Iran escalation that would force a binary choice between Gulf security obligations and relations with Tehran.

7. The U.S. Question After the Midterms

The relevant question is no longer whether Trump would start a conflict with Iran. The United States is already engaged in an active war with Iran, including a naval blockade and repeated strikes. The strategic question is whether the administration intensifies the campaign after the 3 November midterm elections.

Current reporting points to a politically constrained pre-election posture. Trump has said of the war that “it ends right after the election” and that he does not regret it; reporting indicates aides favour keeping the conflict relatively quiet before the vote while saying attacks may intensify afterward. At the same time Trump declined the Saudi crown prince’s request for direct U.S. strikes on the Houthis — first reported by Axios and subsequently carried by Reuters and others — suggesting a distinction between continuing pressure on Iran and opening an additional Yemen campaign.

NERAI ASSESSMENT

If Hormuz remains closed after the midterms and attacks on Saudi infrastructure continue, the probability of renewed or intensified U.S. kinetic action against Iranian military assets is materially higher than the probability of a large U.S. ground or air campaign in Yemen. Washington is more likely to push regional partners to carry a larger share of Red Sea defence. The refusal to strike the Houthis on Riyadh’s behalf is itself the clearest signal of that preference — and it is what makes a Turkish contribution more, not less, likely.

8. How Türkiye Could Be Pulled Into an Iran Confrontation

The central escalation risk is sequencing. Türkiye does not need to choose war with Iran for a confrontation to emerge. If Ankara first deploys ISR, air-defence or naval assets under the Makkah framework, and the U.S. then expands operations against Iran after the midterms, Turkish forces may suddenly be operating inside an active Iran-aligned battlespace.

Türkiye-Iran escalation ladder

Level	Mechanism	Assessment
Rung 1 — Diplomatic friction	Public criticism, pressure over Turkish support to Saudi Arabia, energy and trade signalling	High probability
Rung 2 — Proxy pressure	Iran-aligned groups in Iraq or Syria increase pressure on Turkish positions or interests	Moderate probability if Türkiye deploys
Rung 3 — Maritime targeting risk	Houthi or Iranian-aligned forces threaten Turkish naval or support assets in the Red Sea or Gulf	Low-moderate, high consequence
Rung 4 — Direct incident	A strike, interception or misidentification produces Turkish casualties and retaliation pressure	Low unconditional; materially higher under simultaneous U.S.-Iran escalation

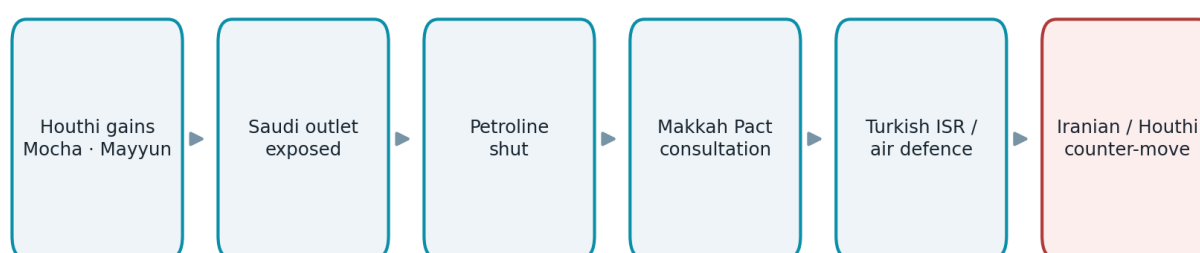


Figure 5. Integrated escalation mechanism. This is an analytical pathway, not a deterministic forecast.

8A. Türkiye-Pakistan-Iran Conflict Model: What NERAI Actually Says

The repository evidence changes the interpretation in an important way: NERAI's base-case forecast does not predict an inevitable Türkiye-Iran confrontation. Türkiye's Military Escalation index is low (8/100) and the 12-month forecast falls to roughly 6/100; Pakistan falls from roughly 22 to 19; Iran from roughly 55 to 30; Saudi Arabia from roughly 40 to 20. In other words, the model's unconditional path is managed de-escalation, not widening war. The confrontation risk appears only after a specific trigger changes Türkiye's operating posture.

The strongest repo-level trigger is unusually specific. NERAI's Türkiye country-profile logic says that routine counter-PKK operations in Iraq and Syria should not be treated as a major escalation signal. By contrast, a Bayraktar or comparable Turkish unmanned-system deployment to a new theatre is explicitly listed as a signal that matters. A Turkish SiHA/IHA deployment to Yemen, the Red Sea or western Saudi Arabia would therefore be analytically different from intelligence-sharing conducted from existing Turkish facilities: it would represent a genuine change in theatre exposure under NERAI's own signal framework.

This supports a stepped risk model rather than a binary intervention question. Pure intelligence-sharing raises political friction but leaves few Turkish assets available for Iran or the Houthis to target. Persistent armed UAV/ISR operations create identifiable Turkish military participation and a targeting problem. Naval escort or air-defence deployment raises the risk further because Turkish personnel and platforms are physically present inside the same battlespace used by Iran-aligned forces. The highest-risk configuration is sequential: Türkiye deploys under the Makkah framework, then Washington intensifies kinetic operations against Iran after the U.S. midterms.

Turkish posture	Exposure	Confrontation risk	Likely Iranian/Houthi response	NERAI reading
Intelligence sharing only	Remote / existing facilities	Low	Political warning, diplomatic pressure, information operations	Does not by itself overturn the NERAI base case
Turkish UAV / ISR assets in theatre	Persistent Turkish military presence	Moderate	Houthi threat designation; Iranian proxy pressure in Iraq/Syria; EW/targeting risk	Country profile treats deployment to a new theatre as a material escalation signal
Naval escort / air defence	Named Turkish platforms and crews exposed	Moderate-High	Maritime harassment, proxy retaliation, risk of Turkish casualties	Creates proximity-driven incident risk
Above + stronger post-midterm U.S. campaign	Simultaneous Turkish and U.S. presence against the Iran-aligned network	High conditional risk	Misidentification, retaliation chain, pressure on Ankara to respond	Most dangerous pathway; not the unconditional base case

Pakistan is a restraining variable, not simply a second intervention force. NERAI's Pakistan trajectory remains elevated domestically but declines on Military Clash over 12 months, while dispute-settlement and international-support signals rise in the source analysis. That points toward mediation and defensive support rather than an expeditionary Yemen campaign. The recent decision to move Pakistani troops closer to the Saudi-Yemeni border increases exposure, but Islamabad's public statement that no military response has yet been discussed under the Makkah Pact is consistent with a graduated-support interpretation rather than automatic war entry.

Iran presents the opposite time profile: the 12-month index forecast moderates, but the near-term environment remains highly dangerous. NERAI's current Forecast Desk notes that the Iran war is “far from over,” that the IRGC remains in full combat posture, and that no confirmed bilateral negotiating channel exists; the probability attached to a jointly agreed U.S.–Iran framework in that desk is only 4%. A falling 12-month escalation index should not be read as a near-term ceasefire forecast. It is compatible with several more months of acute conflict followed by later moderation.

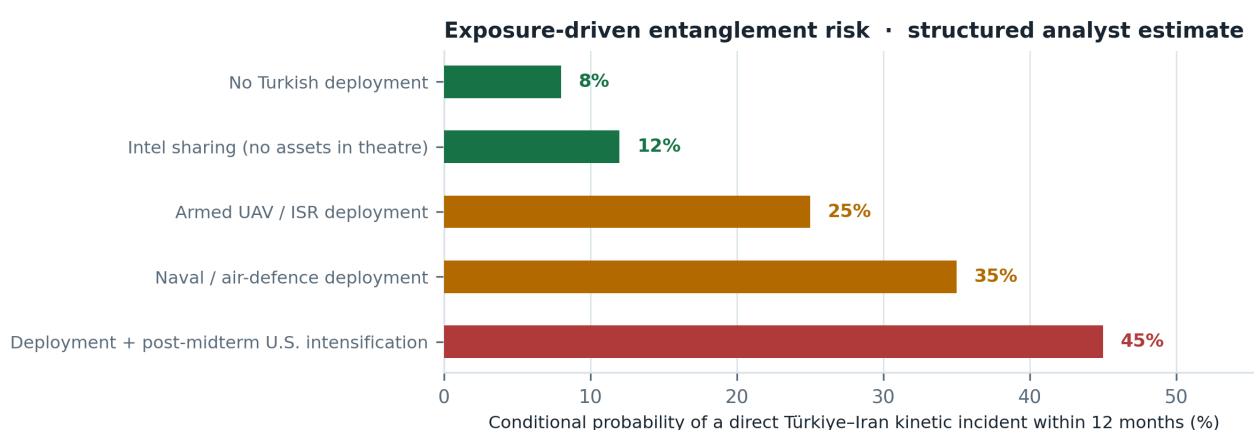


Figure 6. Conditional Türkiye–Iran kinetic-incident risk. Structured analyst estimates informed by NERAI base-case forecasts, the Türkiye country-profile trigger logic, the Makkah Pact and current U.S.–Iran conflict conditions. These are not direct model outputs.

Conditional forecast. On current behaviour, NERAI data support a low direct Türkiye–Iran clash probability. My structured estimate is about 8% over 12 months without Turkish deployment. Intelligence-sharing alone raises that only modestly (about 12%). A persistent Turkish armed UAV/ISR presence raises the estimate to roughly 25%; an overt naval or air-defence deployment to roughly 35%. If such a deployment is already in place when the United States materially intensifies

operations against Iran after the midterms, the conditional probability rises to roughly 45%. The key point is therefore not that conflict is likely; it is that Turkish physical exposure changes the risk regime.

Post-midterm U.S. escalation. Current public reporting and the NERAI near-term conflict picture support a meaningful probability that Washington increases the intensity or target set of its Iran campaign after the November midterms if Hormuz remains closed and there is no credible negotiating channel. I assess a roughly 55-65% probability of some material post-midterm intensification under those conditions, but a much lower probability of a large U.S. ground campaign. The most plausible increase is additional strikes on IRGC naval, missile, command or other strategic military assets. This estimate is analyst judgment, not a direct NERAI model output.

9. Integrated Scenarios

Scenario	Description	6-month estimate	Reading
Controlled collective defence	Türkiye provides ISR / air defence / naval support; Pakistan provides diplomatic and planning support; no direct Iran-Türkiye clash.	45%	Base case
Proxy confrontation	Iranian-aligned actors raise costs for Turkish interests in Iraq/Syria after Ankara supports Riyadh.	25%	Most plausible escalation beyond the base case
Maritime entanglement	Turkish naval or support assets become targets during simultaneous Houthi / Iran escalation.	15%	Low frequency, high consequence
Multi-front Türkiye-Iran confrontation	A Red Sea incident combines with Iraq/Syria proxy pressure and post-midterm U.S. escalation.	10%	Tail risk; requires multiple triggers
Rapid diplomatic containment	Makkah members use the pact mainly for deterrence while Oman/Pakistan diplomacy reduces Hormuz/Red Sea pressure.	5%	Possible but the current kinetic environment makes it the least likely near-term path

Estimates are analyst judgments conditioned on the situation as of 13 September 2026 and sum to 100%.

10. NERAI Forecast: 30 / 90 / 365 Days

30 days

Houthi forces prioritise consolidation of newly gained coastal positions and deterrence against counter-attack. Saudi air operations continue at the elevated tempo already observed — the constraint is not Riyadh's willingness to strike but its unwillingness to re-enter a ground campaign of the 2015 type. Makkah Pact consultations intensify, with the Petroline shutdown rather than the Yemen front the most likely trigger for a formal request. Turkish support remains primarily intelligence, planning and readiness-oriented.

90 days

If Saudi territory and export infrastructure remain under repeated attack, a visible Turkish defensive contribution becomes increasingly plausible, especially air-defence, ISR or maritime support. Pakistan is likely to remain more cautious and mediation-focused. Hormuz remains the principal global energy variable; Bab el-Mandeb becomes the principal regional force-posture variable; the status of the East-West pipeline becomes the principal Saudi-specific variable.

12 months

NERAI's model points to declining Military Escalation indices in Iran, Saudi Arabia, Türkiye and Pakistan, but only a modest decline in Yemen. The most consistent interpretation is not decisive victory but a managed equilibrium in which Houthi territorial leverage persists while regional states seek to contain rather than reverse it.

Indicators that would raise the Türkiye-Iran confrontation risk

- Formal Saudi invocation or public consultation under the Makkah Pact following another high-casualty Houthi/Iran-aligned attack, or a further strike on Saudi export infrastructure.
- Deployment of Turkish air-defence batteries, naval escorts or persistent ISR assets to Saudi Arabia / Red Sea operations — and specifically the appearance of Turkish unmanned systems in a new theatre.
- Iranian or Houthi public designation of Turkish forces or shipping as legitimate targets.
- Post-midterm expansion of U.S. strikes against IRGC naval, missile or nuclear-linked targets.
- Iran-aligned militia attacks on Turkish bases or commercial interests in Iraq or Syria after Turkish support to Riyadh becomes visible.

Indicators that would lower the risk

- Sustained reduction in Houthi attacks on Saudi territory and a negotiated freeze around the new coastal line.
- Repair and reopening of the East-West pipeline without repeat strikes from Iraqi territory.
- Makkah Pact activity remaining limited to planning, exercises and air-defence coordination without Turkish deployment.
- Hormuz transit recovering materially from the current closure regime.
- Oman/Pakistan mediation producing a verifiable reduction in U.S.-Iran maritime attacks before the November midterms.

11. Final Assessment

ANSWER TO THE CENTRAL QUESTION

Yes — Saudi Arabia's strategic loss in Yemen increases the probability that Türkiye is asked to help restore deterrence, and the Makkah Joint Defence Agreement makes such support materially more plausible than it was before August 2026. The 11-12 September closure of the East-West pipeline strengthens that conclusion, because it removes Riyadh's ability to absorb further pressure quietly. However, the most likely Turkish intervention is defensive and enabling rather than a ground war in Yemen. The principal danger is sequencing: if Türkiye deploys under the pact and the United States then intensifies its war with Iran after the midterms, Ankara can become exposed to Iranian or Houthi retaliation without having chosen a direct war. NERAI therefore assesses a Turkish-Iranian confrontation as a tail risk in the base case, but a materially higher conditional risk once Turkish assets enter the Red Sea/Saudi defence architecture.

Confidence: MODERATE-HIGH. The Houthi territorial shift, the Makkah Pact and its institutionalisation, the Petroline shutdown and the current U.S.-Iran war are all verified. The uncertainty lies in political decisions: whether Riyadh formally requests Turkish military support, how Ankara interprets the pact, and whether Washington intensifies operations after the midterms.

Methodology and Data Discipline

This report separates four evidence classes: (1) verified open-source facts, (2) NERAI platform data, (3) analytical inference, and (4) structured analyst forecasts. NERAI indices measure topic intensity relative to a country's own historical series and should not be interpreted as cross-country military-power scores. NERAI corridor transit deviations compare current activity with corridor-specific trailing baselines. The structured probabilities for Turkish intervention and integrated geopolitical scenarios are analyst estimates informed by NERAI signals and current evidence; they are not direct outputs of the NERAI forecasting model.

- NERAI internal source: maritime_corridors.json, as of 7 September 2026.
- NERAI source-report snapshot: country-topic indices and 12-month forecast values, 13 September 2026.
- NERAI Foresight Ledger: corridor disruption probabilities and historical forecast series.
- Granger/lead-lag relationships, where referenced, are treated as temporal predictive associations and not proof of substantive causation.

Selected Source Register

- S1. Government of Pakistan, Ministry of Foreign Affairs, 'Makkah Al-Mukarramah Summit for Joint Defence', 7 Aug 2026.
- S2. Saudi Press Agency, joint statement of the Makkah Al-Mukarramah Summit for Joint Defence, 7 Aug 2026.
- S3. Republic of Türkiye, Ministry of Foreign Affairs, 'Strategic Political and Defence Committee of the Makkah Agreement for Joint Defence — Joint Statement', 31 Aug 2026; secretariat in Riyadh and Pakistani first secretary-general subsequently reported.
- S4. Reuters, 'Pakistan says no military response discussed under Mecca pact over Houthi attacks on Saudi Arabia', 10 Sep 2026.
- S5. Saudi-led coalition statement, 8 Sep 2026: 73 wounded in Houthi attacks on Saudi civilian and energy sites (Al Jazeera, NPR, Arab News, The National).
- S6. CNN, 10 Sep 2026, Houthi capture of Mocha; NPR and Detroit News, 11 Sep 2026; Euronews and NBC News, 12 Sep 2026, on Mayyun/Perim.
- S7. Al Jazeera, 8 Sep 2026, 'Yemeni forces launch counteroffensive against Houthis, vow to retake Sanaa'; Al Jazeera, 13 Sep 2026, on the collapse of that offensive, the 129-raid claim and coalition command splits.
- S8. CNBC and Al Jazeera, 11-12 Sep 2026: Saudi Arabia shuts the East-West (Abqaiq-Yanbu) crude pipeline after drone attacks launched from Maysan province, Iraq; 4-5 million b/d affected; Brent above \$104.

- S9. Reuters / Al-Monitor, 2 Sep 2026: 'Trump aides seek quiet in Iran war but say attacks may intensify after November elections'.
- S10. Axios, 11 Sep 2026, first report that Trump declined the Saudi crown prince's call for U.S. strikes on the Houthis; subsequently carried by Reuters and others.
- S11. Arab News / Reuters, 11 Sep 2026: Trump says he does not regret the Iran war and that it 'ends right after the election'.
- S12. Open-source chronology of the 2026 Strait of Hormuz campaign: closure declared early March 2026 following the 28 Feb strikes; mining; U.S. naval blockade from April; 100+ mines cleared by late August.
- S13. NERAI Strategic Insights Lab, Yemen and the Emerging Red Sea-Hormuz Strategic Balance source report, 13 Sep 2026.
- S14. NERAI internal repository, signal_country_profile.py: Türkiye military-escalation profile; deployment of Bayraktar systems to a new theatre identified as a material escalation signal.
- S15. NERAI Forecast Desk, 11-13 September 2026: Iran conflict remains active, IRGC in full combat posture, no confirmed bilateral negotiating channel; low probability of a jointly agreed U.S.-Iran framework.

About NERAI

NERAI is an AI-enabled strategic intelligence platform combining geopolitical risk monitoring, calibrated forecasting, maritime and corridor intelligence, sanctions/trade-control monitoring and scenario analysis. The platform is designed to convert live external signals into reproducible, decision-relevant intelligence for corporate and institutional users. This report is informational and is not financial, legal or investment advice.

Prepared by Serhan Ayik | Founder & Lead Geopolitical Risk Analyst | NERAI Strategic Insights Lab | Brussels

neraicorp.com | kagan@neraicorp.com